



Allegheny Trail Alliance News

Gov Ridge Announces \$2.7 Million for Rail-Trail Projects

[Overview Map](#)[ATA Information](#)

5/8/98: Governor Ridge Commits \$1.8 million to the Pittsburgh to D.C. Corridor ...

The first continuous 100 miles of the Pittsburgh, PA to Cumberland, MD Trail is now possible with grants announced by Pennsylvania Governor Tom Ridge at a press conference in Rockwood, PA on Friday May 8, 1998. Of the \$1.2 million made available statewide through the Keystone Rails-to-Trails Program, \$355,000 was allocated to trail groups of the Allegheny Trail Alliance (ATA), who collectively are completing the Pittsburgh to Washington, D.C. Trail. The commitment of nearly 30% of the total funding indicates the importance of this trail project to the Commonwealth.

In addition, Governor Ridge announced the release of \$1.5 million from state capital budget funds to build the section south of Ohiopyle State Park. The ATA will complete the 100 miles in Pennsylvania between McKeesport and Meyersdale by the summer of 1999. Seventy continuous miles of trail from McKeesport to Confluence, PA, which follows the scenic Youghiogheny River, will be completed by the end of this summer.

The Governor made his announcement to more than a hundred trail enthusiasts at the trail access area in Rockwood, Somerset County. John Oliver, Secretary of the PA Department of Conservation and Natural Resources stated that this is one of the most exciting rail trail projects in the country. Secretary Oliver praised the high level of dedicated volunteers at the grass roots level who are making this project a reality.

Here's the Governor's press release

NEWS RELEASE

COMMONWEALTH OF PENNSYLVANIA

OFFICE OF THE GOVERNOR

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FOR IMMEDIATE RELEASE

CONTACT Tom Charles, Deputy Press Secretary, (717) 783-1116 or Larissa Brescia,, DCNR, (717) 772-9101

GOV. RIDGE ANNOUNCES \$2.7 MILLION FOR RAIL-TRAIL PROJECTS

PA is No. 1 state for rails-to-trails projects in the nation

ROCKWOOD, Somerset County (May 8) -- Gov. Tom Ridge today announced \$2.7 million in funds for the planning, acquisition and construction of 25 rails-to-trails projects throughout Pennsylvania, including one that will be a part of

a proposed Pittsburgh to Washington, D.C., trail.

Gov. Ridge today made the announcement at the Allegheny Highlands Trail in Somerset County, overlooking the Casselman River. This trail is receiving \$100,000 for restoration of the Salisbury Viaduct. The Governor also today announced \$1.1 million to help non-profit organizations and local governments protect and enhance waterways across the Commonwealth (see accompanying press release).

"Today, I'm pleased to keep Pennsylvania's rail-to-trails program moving on the right track and Pennsylvania's river conservation projects flowing in the right direction -- with a \$3.8 million investment in Pennsylvania's prized natural resources," Gov. Ridge said.

Pennsylvania is the No. 1 state in the nation for rails-to-trails projects. With Gov. Ridge's announcement today, Pennsylvania now can lay claim to 800 miles out of the national total of roughly 10,000 miles of rail-trails.

Since Gov. Ridge took office, Pennsylvania has nearly doubled the number of miles of rail-trails -- from 432 to 800 since 1995. A rail-trail is an abandoned railroad bed that has been converted to trail use for outdoor recreational activities such as biking, hiking, jogging, cross-country skiing and horseback riding.

As part of today's announcement, Gov. Ridge released \$1.5 million in state capital budget funds to convert a nearly six-mile section of rail bed that currently is part of the Allegheny Trail Alliance trail. This trail runs through Ohiopyle State Park and five Southwestern Pennsylvania counties. Once completed, the project will provide a 400-mile continuous trail corridor from Pittsburgh to Washington, D.C.

"This trail passes through some of the most spectacular scenery Pennsylvania has to offer," Gov. Ridge said. "When completed, it is estimated that 2.5 million people will use the trail and will produce an economic boom of \$60 million for the region."

The trail network is easily accessible to more than two million residents in Allegheny, Fayette, Somerset, Washington and Westmoreland counties, and is strategically located within a day's drive of more than 70 percent of the nation's population.

Keystone Ride '98, Gov. Ridge's annual bicycle ride will utilize part of the Allegheny Trail Alliance trail. Gov. Ridge last week announced that his Keystone '98 bike tour will swing through Southwestern Pennsylvania on Sept. 9 and 10. In 1995, Gov. Ridge began the Keystone Ride bike tours of various regions of the state to promote travel, tourism and cycling in Pennsylvania.

The other \$1.2 million in rail-trails grants were made available through The Keystone Rails-to-Trails Program, administered by the state Department of Conservation and Natural Resources (DCNR). The program is part of Gov. Ridge's Community Conservation Partnership -- a four-year, \$75 million grant and technical assistance initiative that helps communities and non-profit organizations conserve natural and cultural resources, provide outdoor recreation, enhance tourism, and foster community and economic development. The program provides up to 50 percent funding for the planning, acquisition and development of rail-trail corridors for public recreational uses.

GOV. RIDGE ANNOUNCES \$1.1 MILLION IN RIVERS CONSERVATION GRANTS

The following is a list, by county, of the rail-trail grant recipients, the grant amounts, and a brief description of the projects

Allegheny County

Friends of the Riverfront Inc., \$25,000 to develop a master plan for the Three Rivers Heritage Trail from 26th Street on Pittsburgh's South Side to the Glenwood Bridge and Sandcastle Street in West Homestead Borough;

McKeesport City, \$30,000 for development on the Youghiogheny River Trail between 15th and 11th streets in

the City of McKeesport;

Montour Trail Council, \$100,000 to further develop the Montour Trail from State Street in the City of Clairton to Jefferson Borough;

Pittsburgh City, \$100,000 to develop a segment of the Ohio Trail between the West End Bridge and Island Avenue in the City of Pittsburgh;

Regional Trail Corporation, \$100,000 to further development of the Youghiogheny River Trail-North in Lincoln and Liberty boroughs; and

Allegheny Valley Land Trust, \$25,750 to develop two segments of the Armstrong Trail along the Allegheny River in Manor and Pine townships.

Blair County

Bellwood Borough, \$4,000 to study the feasibility of developing a one-and-a-half-mile trail that connects Bellwood-Antis Community Park with Bellwood's Main Street Business District.

Bucks County

Bristol Borough, \$45,000 to further develop Bristol Spurline Trail in Bristol Borough between Cleveland and Railroad avenues.

Butler County

Buffalo Township, \$27,100 to rehabilitate two bridges on the Buffalo-Freeport Community Trail in Buffalo and Summit townships.

Clarion County

Allegheny Valley Trails Association, \$100,000 to develop the Clarion Highlands segment of the Allegheny Valley Rail-Trail in Ashland and Elk townships; and

Armstrong County Conservancy, \$20,000 to acquire two parcels of land totaling approximately 55 acres along Redbank Creek and the proposed Armstrong Trail in Madison Township.

Clearfield County

Clearfield County Rails to Trails Association, \$50,000 to further develop the Grampian Line rail-trail in Grampian and Curwensville boroughs; and

Headwaters Charitable Trust, \$5,000 to improve a four-mile section of the Clarion/Little Toby Creek Train in Washington Township.

Cumberland County

Cumberland Valley Rails-to-Trails Council, \$39,400 to develop the Cumberland Valley Trail in Shippensburg and Southampton townships and Newville.

Crawford County

Union Township, \$7,500 to develop a rail-trail master plan for the five-mile Ernst Bike Trail and begin studying the feasibility of extending this trail an additional 10 miles in Conneaut Lake Borough to the southern border of Meadville City.

Delaware County

Haverford Township, \$14,000 to study the feasibility of developing an approximate one mile rail-trail from Township Line Road to Eagle Road in Haverford Township.

Elk County

Ridgway Borough, \$20,000 to develop trailhead for the Clarion/Little Toby Creek Trail in the Borough of Ridgway.

Fayette County

Fayette County, \$60,000 to develop a three-mile segment of the Sheepskin Rail Trail in Dunbar Borough and Dunbar Township.

Luzerne County

Pittston City, \$24,000 to develop a master plan for an eight-and-a-half-mile railroad right-of-way that extends from Duryea Borough south to Wilkes-Barre City.

Philadelphia County

Schuylkill River Development Council, \$100,000 to develop the Schuylkill River Park and Trail between Spring Garden and Spruce streets in the City of Philadelphia.

Somerset County

Somerset County, \$100,000, for restoration of the Salisbury Viaduct on the Allegheny Highlands Trail in Summit Township.

Susquehanna County

Rail-Trail Council of Northeast PA, \$4,000 to develop a master plan for the Forest City trailhead.

Westmoreland County

Allegheny Township, \$89,000 to develop Tredway River Park, a two-and-a-half-mile trail mile long rail-trail in Allegheny Township.

York County

York County Heritage Rail Trail Authority County, \$100,000 to further develop the York County Heritage Rail Trail, providing the final two-mile link between Hyde, Spring Garden Township and existing trails in the City of York.

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